to such concerns?
Well, people raise concerns without verifying the facts. The fact is, nine years ago, out of our total debt, 86 per cent was lending from Indian banks. But now, the exposure of Indian banks in our total lending is only 32 per cent. Almost 50 per cent of our borrowings are now through international bonds. You will appreciate that international investors are very astute and will subscribe only after due diligence.

Q. How do you respond to critics who say your meteoric rise is because of your proximity to Prime Minister Narendra Modi?
Prime Minister Modi and I are from the same state. That makes me an easy target for such baseless allegations. When I look back at my entrepreneurial journey, I can divide it into four phases. Many will be surprised to know that it all began when Rajiv Gandhi was prime minister. He liberalised the Exim policy and, for the first time, several items were brought in the OGL (open general licence) list. That is what helped me to start an export house. But for Rajiv Gandhi, my journey as an entrepreneur would never have taken off. The second big push I got was in 1991, when the duo of Narasimha Rao and Manmohan Singh initiated sweeping economic reforms. Just like many other entrepreneurs, I too was a beneficiary of those reforms. The third turning point came in 1995 when Keshubhai Patel was sworn in as Gujarat chief minister. Until then, all development in Gujarat was around the NH-8 from Mumbai to Delhi via cities like Vapi, Ankleshwar, Bharuch, Silvassa, Vadodara, Surat and Ahmedabad. He was a visionary and focused on coastal development, and it was that policy change that took me to Mundra and prompted me to build our first port. The rest, as they say, is history.

Q. Which was the fourth turning point?
The fourth turning point was in 2001, when Gujarat witnessed a massive focus on development under chief minister Modi. His policies and their implementation went on to not only change the economic landscape of the state but also brought about social transformation and development of previously underdeveloped areas. It also allowed industries and employment to take off like never before. Today, under his able leadership, we are seeing a similar resurgence at the national and international levels, where a new India is asserting itself. It is unfortunate that such narratives are being pushed to defame me. As I explained, these allegations are baseless and suffer from a recency bias, seeing our group's success through a short-term lens. My professional success is not because of any individual leader but because of the policy and institutional reforms initiated by several leaders and governments over a long period of more than three decades.

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Q. What would you say about Prime Minister Modi's style of leadership?
Prime Minister Modi has provided a visionary and inspirational leadership to India, not just by bringing about significant policy changes but also through various programmes and schemes which directly touch the lives of every Indian. There is hardly any aspect of governance which he has not touched. He is trying hard to bring transformative changes not only in the Indian economy but also pushing for social transformation and inclusive growth. He has through several innovative schemes and their effective implementation also given a strong push to the industrial and economic development of India. Schemes like Aatmanirbhar Bharat, Digital India and Start-up India have acted as economic multipliers, creating endless business and manufacturing opportunities and millions of direct and indirect jobs. The prime minister's equally strong focus on the social sector, agricultural economy and underdeveloped areas of the country with a safety net

AMIT PANCHAL



(From left) Mountaineer Arunima Sinha, Adani and blade runner Kiran Kanojia